

HINDUISM



THE OLDEST OF THE GREAT world religions, Hinduism began in India at least 5,000 years ago. Hindus believe in one great power, or supreme god, called Brahman, that exists in everything. They believe in a cycle of death and rebirth – when we die, our souls live on in another person, animal, or plant. The goal of the Hindu is to live such a good life that the soul breaks this cycle and itself becomes part of Brahman. There are some 733 million Hindus, mostly living in Asia.

Vishnu

Hindus know Vishnu as the preserver. They believe that when there is danger to the Earth, Vishnu protects it. His main task is to keep the balance between good and evil powers. To do this, he has visited the Earth in nine different human and animal forms, including the lord Rama and the god Krishna.



Vishnu

Gods

Hindus worship many gods, each of which represents part of Brahman. Some of the gods can take different forms. Hindus can choose a favourite god; two of the most popular are Hanuman, the intelligent monkey-god, and Lakshmi, the goddess of beauty and wealth. But the most important of all is the holy trinity of Vishnu, Shiva, and Brahma. This group of three makes up Brahman, the supreme god.

Shiva

Hindus know this god as the destroyer. Shiva destroys things which are no longer needed, but also allows new things to be created, so he is said to control life and death. He is shown in many forms. As Lord of the Dance, he brings the dance of life to an end so the new cycle of life can begin.



Ganesha

Ganesha, the elephant-headed god of wisdom and strength, is the son of Shiva and Parvati. Hindus worship him at the beginning of journeys because he is thought to remove obstacles.



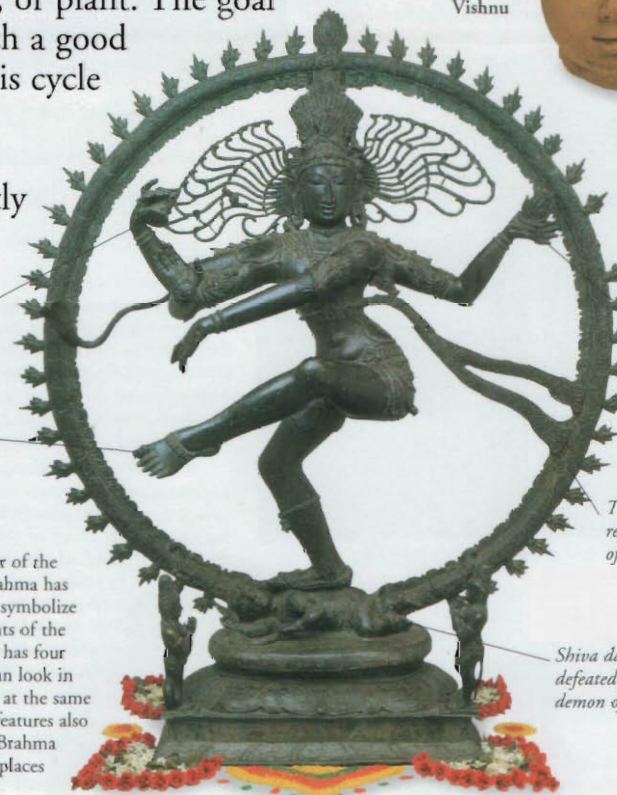
These figures represent holy scriptures.

Shiva beats a drum to summon up a new creation.

His left foot is a symbol of liberation.

Brahma

As the creator of the Universe, Brahma has four arms to symbolize the four points of the compass. He has four faces so he can look in all directions at the same time. These features also suggest that Brahma can be in all places at all times.



Shiva bears a flame as a symbol of destruction.

The ring of flames represents the energy of the Universe.

Shiva dances on the defeated figure of the demon of ignorance.

Sacred texts

Hinduism has many sacred books that explain the religion and instruct people how to lead their lives. The oldest texts are four books known as the *Vedas*. These contain hymns to the gods and texts telling priests how to carry out their duties. At the end of the *Vedas* are the *Upanishads*, which are philosophical discussions about religious belief. The *Puranas* are a series of books discussing and explaining the *Vedas*. The *Laws of Manu* provide teachings about everyday life.

Rig-Veda

The oldest and most sacred of the *Vedas* is the *Rig-Veda*. It contains some 1,000 hymns of praise to 33 of the most important of the gods. Like the other *Vedas*, it was originally composed in around 1200 BC, and passed on by word of mouth. The texts were written down in Sanskrit in around AD 1400.



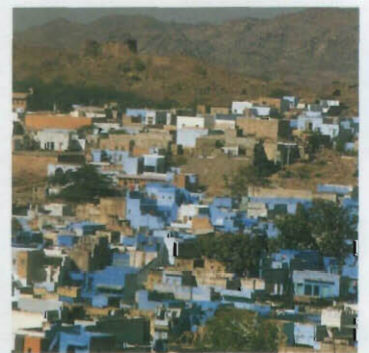
Indra is the Vedic god of conquest. He is a warrior and a destroyer of demons.

In the *Bhagavad-Gita*, Krishna drives the warrior Arjuna's chariot.



The epics

Two great epic poems tell stories in which the gods come to Earth. The *Mahabharata* is probably the longest poem ever written. Its 100,000 verses tell of Vishnu visiting Earth as Krishna. It contains the text known as the *Bhagavad-Gita*, the Song of the Lord. The *Ramayana* tells a story in which Vishnu comes to Earth as lord Rama.



Blue houses in Jodhpur were for Brahmins.

Caste system

Hinduism divides people up into four separate groups, or *varnas*. The four groups are Brahmins (generally priests), Kshatriyas (soldiers and rulers), Vaishyas (traders and farmers), and Shudras (servants). These broad divisions are split into smaller groups called *jatis*, or castes. Traditionally, people would not have anything to do with castes lower than their own, but nowadays there is much more social flexibility.